the *Parishishtaparvan*, which tells the story of his exploits, say that he found a strong ally in King Parvatka of the Himalayas. With a suitable army, the reformers headed to the modern Magadha region to point their swords at Dhana Nanda. Maurya's first efforts were unsuccessful, but he fought on and after a long series of battles managed to finally capture Nanda's capital city of Pataliputra in 322 BCE.

The capture of Pataliputra was the first step in piecing together the powerful Maurya Empire that would last for more than a century and recast India as a unified people. With Nanda under his power, Maurya turned northward to confront the Macedonians left behind by Alexander the Great. It took several years of military campaigning in Punjab and the former Kingdom of Porus to remove the conquering statesmen from their posts and reclaim the northern section of India, and by that time, one of the Macedonian generals had returned to lay claim to the land he'd helped Alexander conquer.

It was General Seleucus who came back to the Indus River Valley following his successful claim to rule Babylon and much of Alexander's adjacent Asian lands. Expecting to find a large tract of land along the river in the hands of his fellow Macedonians, Seleucus instead found himself facing off against the newly born Mauryan Empire. It was exactly this scenario for which Emperor Maurya and Vishnugupta had been preparing.

Seleucus fought against the armies of Maurya for two years before admitting defeat. He was not content to retreat with nothing, however, and so signed a formal peace treaty with the emperor that was celebrated with the intermarriage between the families of the rulers. The Macedonian princess, one of the daughters of Seleucus (though her name is not certain) was married to Emperor Maurya. She stayed in India, while her father and his army went back to Persia with a gift of 500 war elephants.

Over the course of 139 years of Mauryan rule, the empire created a great deal of wealth by importing and exporting goods to and from China, Sumatra, Persia, Ceylon, and Mediterranean cities. It was the era of the famed Silk Road, an established trade route that linked every major city and port between Constantinople, capital of the Roman Empire in modern Turkey and Beijing, China. By focusing their merchant ventures in local cities along the route, the Mauryan people were able to sell a collection of silks and spices from local producers, as well as exotic items such as rugs, precious metals and stones, perfumes, and fabrics that had been procured from their own travels to nearby regions.